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Excerpt from the book titled 'Waiting for my acceptance letter'

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~To my lovely family ~

Mom, you have always been my infinite source of motivation and inspiration. I cannot be the person I am, if it isn't for you. Thank you for your unconditional love, patience and acceptance. You are and always be the best!

Papa, you have always been the necessary support that I needed to survive as a young kid. Even though I do not thank you enough, I want to let you know that you have been successful in providing me with a safe environment, for which I am grateful from the bottom of my heart.

Andy, you are a precious gift that I will always cherish and treasure. You are exceptionally creative and an amazing researcher. Thank you for showing me what it meant to chase my dreams. No amount of words will be ever enough to express what you mean to me.

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Billy, my only Billy. Your incredible vigor to advocate for your achievements and the practice of grounding yourself in a kind conduct are a constant reminder of your strength and compassion. Thank you for showing me what it takes to be that courageous. You have a very special place in my heart and I promise to never let go.

With respect, warmth and so much love,
J.

2027, India.

For those in the Western world who don't know much about India. India is a beautiful country. I say it is beautiful because people on the same block speak different languages. While I speak only three, English is the official language of India and having completed my schooling from a Roman Catholic institution, I am most comfortable expressing myself in English. It is not to say that, that makes other languages less important. I believe they are equally important. I am quite an enthusiast myself in learning two more. Like, every country has its own sets of challenges, India too grapples with the problems of heat waves, water shortages, air pollution as well as women safety. I mentioned these challenges because they have had an impact on me personally and also had an effect on the way I have experienced the country. It is quite difficult to understand such challenges when one has only been in a developed country, specifically in those neighborhoods that have accessibility and availability of resources. Hence, for those who haven't seen or lived the reality by physically visiting another country or haven't stayed in the country long enough might find it difficult to relate to. This book is to emphasize on the mentioned challenges in order to draw your attention to how much of a constructive or destructive effect those challenges can have on individuals such as myself who have returned to their home country after staying abroad for a few years. I will also be sharing about the experiences from what my friends and family have faced as students or female working professionals.

Chapter 1

I was born in a city located in the State of Maharashtra. My maternal grandfather, whom I had a chance to meet when I was very young, was a doctor. He was a doctor for Ayurvedic medicines and often made his own medicines at home. He was very well known within the community where he took care of many patients charging them very little money or no money if they were very poor and in need of treatment. From what I heard from my father, that his father was a painter, he was also passionate about designing building interiors, but due to a lack of formal education in Architecture he would not land contracts on major designing projects and often would put his skills to paint the interiors. My mother's father on the other hand had a formal education in Ayurvedic medicine, he was also awarded for his service by the city council. While I did not get a chance to meet my maternal grandma, I had a chance to spend time with my paternal grandmother. She often worked in farms or construction sites on hourly wages. The heavy machinery work required so much physical energy, so I often saw her very fit and someone who had excellent food habits. I grew up in an interfaith household. I attended school, a convent and therefore had a chance to meet many students from different minorities as well. Growing up with so much diversity has been one of the best memories I carry from India. If I mention about the houses that belonged to my grandparents, both fell in different clusters of community settlements. One had a different culture than the other. The language of communication as well as the accents for the same language were different between people from these communities, within the same city. As a kid, I usually got confused between a firm 'no' which was considered as an acceptable answer on my father's side of the family but the way to reject offers or help with a firm 'no' was considered impolite on my mother's side of the family. Buying a new dress, staying up to date with the recent technology like a new wireless phone was often not seen as necessary on my father's side among my aunts but it was often welcomed and encouraged by my mother's sisters.

My father, was very athletic and a regular swimmer. He worked small office jobs before he made it as an employee working for a power distribution company. This job gave him accommodation, a decent salary and the means to live a dignified life. My mother, who was really bright as a student, was especially good at mathematics and biology. She used to tutor other students growing up before she landed a job of a high school biology teacher and also experienced the job security just like my father did. So, I grew up with working parents. Since both my parents came from a different faith, there were people who supported the marriage and those who opposed it. I would hear stories narrated in a funny manner by my father when he used to casually mention about when he fell in love in my mother. It was quite clear to me that even after my birth and during my childhood days I could feel the resistance held upon the after years of marriage of my parents when we used to visit some of our relatives. There were many cultural differences -including the various food choices on both sides. My mother had strict dietary habits. Food in India, consists of spices utilized during cooking. But my mother usually made very simple and steamed food with very little oil in it.

Salads were a necessary part of our daily diet. I heard people comment on my mother's cooking as too bland for their consumption.

We had visitors coming to our house when both my parents left for work and grandma (father's mother) would be home. There were days when all the food would be consumed and when I would return from school I would not ask grandma for meals nor did I learn to prepare snacks out of bread. This used to bother my mother as her concern was that her daughter would go hungry, she never opposed on others not visiting or eating the food she used to prepare before leaving for her job. What bothered her was something that would bother any mother on the face of the earth when food that was prepared for her kid was consumed by other adults who just happen to stop by the house or dropped by for short stays. On Sundays, my father used to cook meals for us but otherwise my mother took care of her job as well as cooking food for me, my father, my grandmother and other family relatives.

I was disciplined to join a sport at a very young age. I often accompanied my father to take swimming lessons. I also enjoyed numerous bicycle rides with my father in parks, who also educated me on the traffic rules during the lessons. As a teenager, he then taught me to ride a motor bike and also taught me how to drive a car. My mother always hated the idea of me spending time in the kitchen, she often used to send me off with my father to attend many social events -like advocating for higher education, reading books and attending the library talks that used to take place near our house. I therefore could discipline myself at learning new skills, networking with people and spending time outdoors but I couldn't learn to cook until very recently. As a kid, I always travelled with my parents and did not know what it meant to make use of public transportation. One incident I recall from a day when Papa wasn't available to pick me up after school, my mother took her leave for the day and cancelled all her classes to take me home. We hopped on a tuk-tuk (a three wheeler motored vehicle) then got on a bus to reach our destination, our house. While standing in the queue to board the bus, she yelled, 'Keep your hands away from me and my kid and stand further away from us'. At the time it did not strike to me that this incident pointed out to safety concerns related to women and children when they chose public transportation over private vehicles. I was under the protection of my mother so I couldn't clearly make an observation from the incident. My father did not prefer private transportation himself and often made us travel by a bus or train to places. When I was in high school, my mother had already established her reputation in teaching, not only as an excellent educator but was also known to guide her students for their higher studies. My father on the other hand was promoted to the position of a senior officer. My mother's career path as well as her career growth felt more stable compared to that of my father's, as the company (previously under public sector) he worked for was now owned by a private entity and his job became more demanding and stressful. He managed his position as an executive officer and was left with very little time to spend with his family. Whenever he yelled at me when I demanded to take our private vehicle to an event, I was reminded of his grounding in staying humble and not letting luxury dictate my life. As someone as busy as him, owning a private vehicle saved time but his habits stayed old and gold, when he

preferred taking the bus to work. I also observed that incidents such as the one I described before when my mother asked the stranger to keep his distance from us, travel with my father in public transportation felt less riskier. Those experiences were only observed while travelling with my mother.

During the summers, mother also told me that I should not wear body hugging clothes made out of warm fabrics. She was quite liberal when it came to my dressing choices. My grandma often encouraged me to wear skirts and shirts or shorts and t-shirts. My father was authoritative when it came to my clothing choices specifically for the events he and I would attend, either to raise funds or attend meetings to discuss about a social causes like advocating for necessary supplies for school going kids who came from the marginalized communities. I didn't understand the irony, the instructions from my father on my dressing choices who believed that I was free to decide and I had my lawful rights but at the same time his instructions emphasized more on wearing official clothing over casual clothes at the events. My mother often told me , 'People wont judge you for what you wear, you will be valued for what you think'. I remember facing a dilemma quite often due to different parenting styles and difficulty in deciding which suggestion or instruction to go with to not make either of them upset. But I tried to learn about the reasoning behind their instructions. I tried to think what went through their minds that I wasn't able to understand. Leaving them aside, grandma had always been frank, she never confused me. I had not thought about this in terms of female safety, because I did not have to think about it as a teenager. My mother wanted me to wear clothes that were breezy during the summers, her concern was mostly related to the summer heat and my health. There had always been some connection with my safety and the way my father defended me from those in the society who never understood that dressing choices was never the core issue. He was more cautious especially when we took public transportation. He just wanted to save us the time and the effort from unnecessary attention I would get as a young teenager. He wanted me to stay focused on my grades, while he could not hide how proud he was to take me to those social events. From what I understand, he was a proud father of a young girl. He helped me to learn and build leadership skills from those events that we attended but also staying reserved enough in the social environment to keep away any sociopaths or stalkers from approaching me. I get it Papa!

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